

HALF-LIFE²

— EPISODE ONE —

At last, the waiting's over and we find out what happened after that silly time stopping explosion at the end of *Half Life 2*

WARNING

If you haven't played Half Life 2 before reading this review, you haven't lived yet, and probably won't understand a thing. Make sure you play HL2 before playing HL2:EP1

I hate it! This whole episodic release thing, that is. What's with this whole Episode 1, 2 and 3 thing? Waiting for *Star Wars* was bad enough, without Valve doing their Lucas impressions!

I finished *Half Life 2* in two sittings—that's how much I love this series from Valve. However, at the end of it all, I was left speechless: "How could they end it like that? What were they smoking? Arrrrrrgh!"

Anyway, rants about the ending of *HL2* apart, I had to wait three days to get my hands on a decent enough graphics card before I was willing to fire *Half Life 2: Episode 1 (HL2:EP1)* up. I played it on a AMD Athlon 64 3200+, 1 GB DDR 400 RAM with a ATI Radeon X1900 XT—told you I waited for a good card!

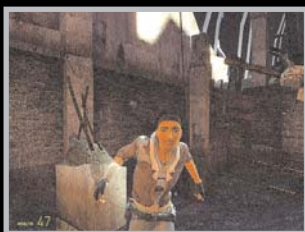
I had the volume up high and was waiting eagerly for an explanation of how Alyx Vance and I had survived that time stopping explosion—it never came...

I won't spoil it for those of you who haven't played this yet, but suffice to say, I was more confused about the events of the end of *Half Life 2* after watching the beginning of *Episode 1!*

Anyway, on to the game! It's typical *Half Life 2*, the only difference being that you start with the Gravity Gun from the get go. Of course it takes awhile before you get any more weapons, so it's all defying the laws of physics till then! The story is spelt out in the many screenshots of this review, and it involves some good graphics, amazing voice acting and very nice looking character models. The



1 If she likes *me*, how come everyone else is touching her?



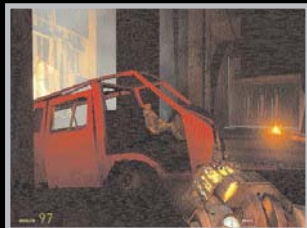
2 She's happy to see me again. Do I get a big hug?



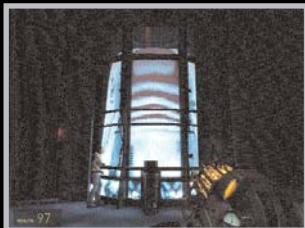
3 Typical of dads; they always spoil the romance!



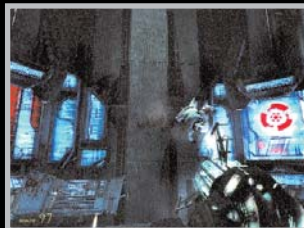
4 I can't resist throwing my old computer away...



7 We go for a drive; turns out to be a rollecoaster of a ride



8 A big guy tries to butt in on our conversations...



9 The next guy gets his brains splattered on the wall



10 I save the world again, temporarily though...



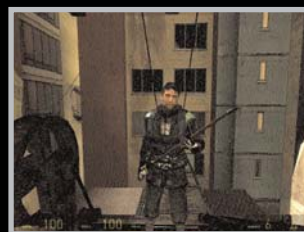
13 Whoops, no more tacos for breakfast from now on



14 That's a big fly. Rocket-propelled-flyswatter time!



15 Is it me or is this *déjà vu*? Stop copy-pasting code!



16 There's Barney, and he found my crowbar. Oh joy!